



■ By Farzand Ahmed and Amitabh Srivastava

The water in his ground floor house has already covered his chairs and dining table. So Vikash Ranjan Sinha, a grocery shop owner in Madhepura, moved up to the first floor with his octogenarian parents, wife and three children, including an infant. They have been there for the past week—hoping either for the flood waters to recede or the Government to send boats to rescue them. Their food stocks are running out and the cooking gas cylinder is almost empty. Yet, despite three weeks of Bihar being inundated by floods from the overflowing Kosi river, the Government is conspicuous by its absence. And Sinha is running out of the only thing that has kept him and his family alive—hope.

At the Madhepura railway station, not far from where Sinha lives, there are 100 personnel of the State Auxiliary Police (SAP), who are marooned and hungry too. The irony is that the SAP had been set up by the Bihar government to provide relief and rescue precisely when such emergencies strike the state. Yet, with no proper coordination, they, too, are holed up at the railway station waiting for rescue boats to arrive. On the streets of Madhepura, lawlessness prevails and department stores are looted even as the police looks on. For the people of Bihar, it is a double-whammy. Not only are they facing the brunt of nature's fury but they have to suffer government apathy as well.

Yet, even everyday as the numbers affected mount, there is no sign that either the state or the Central Government is capable of bringing the situation under control. By last week over 2.4 million people were rendered homeless and though the Government claims that only 18 people have died, social workers and citizens believe that more than 1,000 may have died. In Saharsa, about 30 km from Madhepura, in a relief camp set up by a social organisation, Dinesh Shah, a farm labourer, scans every new face. He still has hope that his